government and citizenry interact, with a public record and independent oversight of each interaction.

Secondly, as most black money is believed to be generated in the registration of properties, details of all property transactions, including names of the two parties and the value of the sale, must be entered on the concerned public authority's website as soon as the deal is concluded. In today's IT environment such transparency is easy to achieve. The possibility of public scrutiny, as opposed to that of the income tax department in private, would make a difference to the generation of black money. It should also provide some relief to citizens who are otherwise at the mercy of an unaccountable bureaucracy.

Thirdly, there is the issue of *election funding*. There is a strong argument for reforming current practices. First, the limits on spending should go, but so must the *practice of allowing anonymous donations to political parties*. In fact, political parties must be brought under the purview of the RTI Act. The argument that political parties are not public bodies simply does not hold water. Political parties are claimants to the government and, if they come to power, will control every aspect of the economic activity in the country. The citizen is fully entitled to know about their financial transactions. *A demonetization allegedly aimed at ending the generation of unaccounted income that has nothing to say about the funding of political parties is not credible.*[9]

Though we had such clear-sighted opinions available to all, in public debates after demonetization, BJP spokespersons would often derisively suggest that anyone opposing the measure was in favour of black money and corruption.[10]

I quickly discovered the most effective way to silence them was to ask: 'If the government was serious about tackling corruption as also about a digital India, why did the BJP not set an example by publicly declaring that they would henceforth not accept any political donations in cash but only through transparent digital payments?'

Unfortunately, the BJP has not done this. In the 2017 and 2018 Budgets, election funding has become even more opaque. Companies are no longer required to disclose details of political funding in their annual accounts. A new non-transparent method of election funding through Electoral Bonds has also been introduced, raising concerns about an escalation to an entirely new level of crony corruption. The 2018 Budget also made it retrospectively legal for political parties to accept funding from foreign corporations – giving every political party